Return: The Second Temple and the Silent Years

Ezra 1; 3; 6; Nehemiah 1; 4; 8; Malachi 3–4

The big idea: God brought his people home from Babylon as he promised. They rebuilt the temple and the walls and heard his law again, but their hearts kept drifting. Malachi called them to return to God and promised the Lord would come to his temple. After four hundred silent years, he did: Jesus, the greater glory.

Before you meet: Read

Ezra 1:1–4; 3:10–13 | Haggai 1:3–9; 2:3–9 | Nehemiah 4:7–23 | Nehemiah 8:1–12 | Malachi 3:1–7; 4:1–6

Open (5 minutes)

When have you come home after a long time away? What had changed, and what had stayed the same?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"The LORD stirred up the _____ of Cyrus king of Persia, so that he made a proclamation throughout all his kingdom." *(Ezra 1:1)*

"Not by might, nor by power, but by my _____, says the LORD of hosts." *(Zechariah 4:6)*

"For Ezra had set his heart to _____ the Law of the LORD, and to do it and to teach his statutes and rules in Israel." *(Ezra 7:10)*

"Each labored on the work with one hand and held his _____ with the other." *(Nehemiah 4:17)*

"Do not be grieved, for the _____ of the LORD is your strength." *(Nehemiah 8:10)*

"Return to me, and I will _____ to you, says the LORD of hosts." *(Malachi 3:7)*

Discuss

1. At the temple's foundation the old men wept and others shouted for joy. Why did both reactions make sense? *Ezra 3:11–13; Haggai 2:3*

2. Haggai said, Consider your ways. What would change if you put God's priorities ahead of your own projects? *Haggai 1:3–9*

3. Nehemiah's people prayed and also set a guard. How do prayer and practical action work together in your life? *Nehemiah 4:9, 14, 17*

4. When Ezra read God's word, the people wept, and then were told to rejoice. Why do we need both? *Nehemiah 8:8–12*

5. The exiles came home to the land but kept drifting from God. Why is it possible to return outwardly without returning in your heart? *Malachi 1:6–8; 3:6–7*

6. God was silent for four hundred years but kept working. Where have you seen God at work when he seemed silent? *Galatians 4:4; Luke 2:25–32*

Apply this week

Pick one short passage this week. Study it, do one thing it says, and share it with one person, as Ezra did. Then consider your ways: name one place where God comes last in your time or money, and give him first place there.

Memory verse

"Not by might, nor by power, but by my Spirit, says the LORD of hosts."

Zechariah 4:6

Pray

Thank God that he keeps his promises, even after long silence. Ask him to turn your heart back to him, and thank him that the Father runs to meet everyone who comes home through Jesus.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 18

Return: The Second Temple and the Silent Years

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Ezra 3:10–13 and Nehemiah 8:1–10 aloud together.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 2, 4, and 5 matter most.
5 min	Walk the group through the Coming Home timeline and the Silent Years chart in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 19 (Luke 1–2; John 1:1–18).

Main points to land

1. God kept his promise to bring the exiles home, even naming Cyrus in advance (Ezra 1:1; Isaiah 44:28).
2. The returned exiles rebuilt the temple by God's Spirit, not by might, and Haggai promised its latter glory would be greater (Zechariah 4:6; Haggai 2:9).
3. Ezra and Nehemiah rebuilt the walls and restored God's word to the center of the people's life (Ezra 7:10; Nehemiah 8:8–10).
4. The people returned to the land without fully returning to God. Malachi called them back and promised the Lord would come to his temple (Malachi 3:1, 7).
5. After four hundred silent years, God sent his Son in the fullness of time. Jesus is the greater glory of the temple (Galatians 4:4; Luke 2:27–32).

Answer key (Observe)

1. spirit
2. Spirit
3. study
4. weapon
5. joy
6. return

Questions people will ask

Why was God silent for four hundred years?
Scripture does not tell us all his reasons. It does show that he was still working: the world gained a common language, the Old Testament was translated into Greek, and Roman roads were built. Paul says God sent his Son when the fullness of time had come (Galatians 4:4). Silence is not absence.

What happened to the ark of the covenant?
Scripture never says. It was probably lost or destroyed when Babylon took Jerusalem. Jeremiah even said a day would come when people would no longer miss it (Jeremiah 3:16), because God would dwell with his people in a better way.

Is the 490 years of Daniel 9 connected to forgiving seventy times seven?
Daniel's seventy sevens point to God dealing with sin completely, and many Reformed interpreters see that fulfilled in Christ. Jesus' answer to Peter reads seventy-seven times in the ESV, with seventy times seven in a footnote. The two passages are about different things, so hold any link loosely. Both point to a forgiveness that does not run out.

Why isn't 1 Maccabees in our Bible?
It is a helpful history of the silent years, and it describes the events behind Hanukkah. But the Jewish people never counted it among their Scriptures, and Protestant churches follow that, treating it as useful history and not as God's inspired word (WCF 1.3).

Closing prayer

Father, you kept your promise to bring your people home, and you kept working through four hundred silent years. Turn our hearts back to you. Let your word be central among us, and let the joy of the LORD be our strength. Thank you for sending your Son in the fullness of time, the greater glory, the Lord who came to his temple. Amen.

Full lesson with illustrations and diagrams: 490.life/bible-study